POWER, PERCEPTION, AND PILLS: A GENDERED PERCEPTION OF EMERGENCY CONTRACEPTION

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ABSTRACT

Emergency contraception (EC) is a vital intervention for reducing unintended pregnancies, yet its awareness and use remain shaped by gendered power dynamics, stigma, and misconceptions. In Bangladesh, limited knowledge and social judgment continue to hinder equitable access. This study employed a cross-sectional mixed-methods design in Raicho village, Cumilla district, involving 27 married adults (19 females, 8 males). Semi-structured interviews were conducted, and data were analyzed using descriptive statistics and thematic analysis. Results showed that 78% of respondents had heard of EC, primarily through mass media, but only 22% correctly identified the effective timing window. Stigma was reported by one-third of participants, disproportionately affecting women. Pharmacies were the preferred source of EC (73%), while healthcare providers were identified as the most trusted source of information. Qualitative findings underscored women's disproportionate burden in preventing unintended pregnancies and highlighted inconsistent male involvement in reproductive decision-making. These findings illustrate how gendered perceptions and structural barriers limit the effectiveness of EC, reinforcing inequities in reproductive health. Addressing these challenges requires innovative, gender-sensitive programming, stronger provider–client communication, and active engagement of men as partners. By situating local insights within global discourse, this study contributes to building bridges in public health, ensuring that reproductive health strategies are inclusive, equitable, and responsive to diverse sociocultural contexts.

Keywords: emergency contraception, gender perception, reproductive health, stigma, Bangladesh

Themes: Sexual and Reproductive Health, Health Promotion and Communication, Health Equity, Policy, and Global Governance

Biography



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